

The UI/UX Bible: From AI Slop to Awwwards

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0. How to use this bible

This document lifts any website from the generic "AI default" look to professional quality, and gives it a real shot at award level — but only if the model follows the process in Part 4 and the critique in Part 17, not just the rules.

Operating instructions for the AI model reading this

1. **Part 1 is binding.** The Prime Directives apply to every task. Parts 5–15 are reference: open the relevant part when you work on that layer (type, color, motion, forms...).
2. **Never start with code.** Run Part 4 first: brief → concept → token system → wireframe. Only then build.
3. **Precedence when rules collide:** (1) the user's explicit brief and brand, (2) accessibility and legibility, (3) usability and clarity, (4) performance, (5) art direction and distinctiveness, (6) trends. The accessibility and performance floors in Parts 13–14 are never traded away for looks.
4. **Content beats rules.** Every rule here serves the specific subject in front of you. If a rule fights the content, the content wins — and say why.
5. **Critique before you present.** Run the Part 17 protocol, fix what it finds, and state plainly what you could not verify (for example, no browser to test real-device performance).
6. **Where the brief is silent, make a choice — never a default.** A default is what you would produce for any similar prompt. A choice is traceable to this subject.

Instructions for the human using it

- **Where to put it:** paste the whole bible into a project, system prompt or rules file. If context is tight, paste Part 1, Part 2, Part 17 and only the parts relevant to the task.
- **Feed it real material:** actual copy, product screenshots, photography, logo, brand colors, competitor links you hate and love. No rulebook compensates for placeholder content — juries and users both spot it.

- **Give the model eyes:** a model that can screenshot its own render and iterate performs dramatically better than one coding blind. Use a browser tool or paste screenshots back.
- **Iterate in passes:** plan → approve the plan → build → critique → fix. One-shot prompts produce median output.

What this can and cannot do

It reliably removes the generic look and raises hierarchy, usability, accessibility and performance to a professional standard. Award-level work additionally needs three things no document supplies: a concept specific to the brand, original assets (photography, illustration, 3D), and human judgment on how motion *feels* across real devices. Treat the award as the ceiling this bible aims at, not a promise it makes.

1. The Prime Directives

These twenty rules are the whole bible compressed. If a model reads nothing else, it reads this.

1. **Decide before you decorate.** Write a one-sentence concept rooted in the subject before writing any code. Every color, typeface, layout and motion choice must trace back to it.
2. **Mine the subject's world.** Distinctiveness comes from the subject's materials, vernacular, history, place and audience — not from this year's trends.
3. **Kill the defaults.** If a choice is what you would produce for any similar prompt (Inter, an indigo-to-violet gradient, a centered hero with two buttons, three icon cards), replace it with one made for this brief. Part 2 lists the tells.
4. **Spend boldness in one place.** One signature moment people would screenshot; everything around it quiet, disciplined and fast.
5. **Typography carries the personality.** One or two families chosen on purpose, a real type scale, display type set with intent (tracking, line-height, wrapping), body text at 16–20px with 45–75 characters per line.
6. **Hierarchy is contrast.** Every view has at least three clearly distinct levels (size, weight, color, space) and exactly one primary action.
7. **Color is a token system.** A tinted neutral ramp, one or two brand hues, semantic colors, built in OKLCH; the accent is scarce so that it means something.

8. **Space is a material.** One spacing scale. Space inside a group is clearly smaller than space between groups. Section spacing is generous and varied, never uniform.
9. **Grid first, then break it on purpose.** Vary the rhythm from section to section. Never stack the same "heading + card row" module down the page.
10. **Real content only.** Real copy, product, numbers, people and photos. No lorem ipsum, no "Acme", no invented testimonials, logos or stats, no stock clichés.
11. **Motion must answer something:** feedback, a state change, spatial continuity, or one orchestrated moment. Animate `transform` and `opacity` only, ease-out on entry, 100–300ms for most UI (up to about 500ms for layout changes), and honor `prefers-reduced-motion`.
12. **Every element has every state.** Default, hover, focus-visible, active, disabled, loading; every view has empty, error and success states.
13. **Accessibility floor (WCAG 2.2 AA):** 4.5:1 text contrast (3:1 for large text and UI parts), visible focus, targets at least 24×24px (aim for 44×44), semantic HTML, real alt text, fully keyboard operable.
14. **Performance floor:** LCP ≤ 2.5s, INP ≤ 200ms, CLS ≤ 0.1 at the 75th percentile on mobile. Sized and modern-format images, preloaded hero asset and primary font, reserved space for media.
15. **Mobile is designed, not collapsed.** Compose small screens deliberately; keep primary actions in thumb reach; nothing essential depends on hover.
16. **Clarity beats cleverness.** A stranger knows what this is, who it's for and what to do next within five seconds of landing.
17. **Consistency is navigation.** The same thing looks and behaves the same everywhere; an action keeps one name through the whole flow.
18. **Finish the details.** Optical alignment, balanced headline wraps, radii scaled by hierarchy, one icon family, real typographic quotes and dashes, favicon, social image, 404 page, focus ring, selection color.
19. **Critique before shipping.** Screenshot at 375, 768 and 1440px, run Part 17, fix the findings, then look again.
20. **Remove one accessory.** When you think it's done, delete the weakest decorative element. The page is almost always better for it.

2. Diagnosing AI slop

AI slop is what you get when a model fills taste decisions nobody made: it samples the statistical center of its training data, and the center of "modern web UI" is one very repeated look. The fix is not a different trend — it is making each decision for this subject. (prg.sh, [Superdesign](#), [925studios](#))

First-order tells (the classic starter pack)

Tell	Why it reads as slop	Do instead
Inter / Roboto / Poppins as the whole identity	The zero-decision font; seen on millions of pages	Pick a family whose shapes echo the subject (Part 5)
Indigo/violet accent, purple-to-blue gradient	Inherited from years of <code>bg-indigo-500</code> demo code	Derive the palette from the subject's world (Part 6)
Centered hero: headline, subline, two buttons	The median layout of every landing page	Open with the most characteristic thing in the subject's world: product in use, a demo, a bold image, type as image
Row of three rounded cards with small icons	Content chopped into identical boxes, no hierarchy	Give items unequal weight; use lists, tables, editorial layouts, or one big example
Same border-radius and <code>rgba(0,0,0,.1)</code> shadow on everything	Flattens hierarchy; screams component kit	Radii and elevation scaled by importance; shadows tinted to the surface
Glowing gradients and blobs as decoration	Signals nothing; costs paint time	Use gradients only for light, material or data
Emoji as icons or bullet points	Casual, inconsistent, unlabelled	One icon family with consistent stroke, or no icons
Pulsing "Live" or "New" pills on things that are neither	Decoration pretending to be information	Only real status gets a badge
Thick colored border on one side of a card	Now one of the most recognizable AI signatures	Hierarchy through type and space

Tell	Why it reads as slop	Do instead
Fade-and-slide-up on every section, hover-lift on every card	Motion with no hierarchy, so nothing matters	One orchestrated moment; motion that answers actions
"John Doe", "Acme", fake logos, "10k+ happy users"	Placeholder energy destroys trust instantly	Real names, real numbers, or leave the section out
Forms without labels, validation, error or empty states	The functional gap: looks done, isn't	Full state coverage (Part 10, Part 12)

Second-order tells (what models do when told "don't be generic")

These are the new defaults. Each is legitimate for *some* brief, but none should appear just because the model was told to avoid the first list.

- A warm cream background (around #F4F1EA) with a high-contrast serif and a terracotta or clay accent.
- A near-black background with one acid-green or vermilion accent.
- Broadsheet cosplay: hairline rules, zero radius, dense newspaper columns.
- Tracked-out ALL-CAPS eyebrow labels above every heading.
- One word of a headline set in italic, bold or a different color.
- Meta strings joined by middle dots ("Design · Build · Ship"), labels built as "WORD — fragment".
- Numbered markers (01 / 02 / 03) on content that is not actually a sequence.
- A monospace font for small data labels when there is no real data.
- "→" appended to every link and button.
- Bento grids for content that isn't modular; glassmorphism panels; animated grain over everything.
- The "tasteful free font" rotation: Space Grotesk, DM Sans, Plus Jakarta Sans, Geist, Instrument Serif, Satoshi, Clash Display. Fine fonts, now defaults.

Copy tells

- Verbs: unlock, elevate, supercharge, revolutionize, empower, streamline, seamless, effortless, leverage.

- Shapes: "Your all-in-one platform for...", "X, reimagined", "Built for the way you work", three-adjective headlines, rhetorical questions as headings.
- Symptoms: every feature "powerful", every workflow "seamless", no concrete numbers, nouns or names.

Four tests that catch slop

1. **The logo-swap test:** swap the logo and headline for a competitor's. If the page still works, it has no identity.
2. **The prompt-twin test:** imagine the median output for the same prompt. Wherever yours matches it, revise that part and say what you changed.
3. **The squint test:** blur the screenshot. You should see one focal point and a clear order of importance, not an even field of boxes.
4. **The "why" test:** point at any element and say why it exists and why it looks that way. "It looks modern" is not an answer.

3. What Awwwards actually scores

Design and usability are 70% of the score; the flashy creative layer is only 20%. Most ambitious sites lose on speed, mobile and clarity, not on imagination. ([Awwwards evaluation system](#))

Criterion	Weight	What the jury is really checking
Design	40%	Art direction, typography, layout, color, composition, consistency
Usability	30%	Navigation, clarity, speed, responsiveness, accessibility — can a stranger use it
Creativity	20%	Originality of the concept and of its execution and interaction
Content	10%	Quality of copy, imagery and video, and how well they're integrated

How the vote works

- Each approved site goes to at least 18 jurors; the three scores furthest from the average are dropped. Voting lasts five days.
- 6.5 or more earns an Honorable Mention. The day's highest scorer takes Site of the Day.
- Every Site of the Day goes to a developer jury; a score above 7 adds a Developer Award for technical execution, accessibility, performance and code quality.
- The eight top scorers each month are re-judged for Site of the Month; monthly winners go forward to Site of the Year.

What jurors reward

From a working Awwwards juror with nine Sites of the Day ([Hon Tran](#)):

- **A point of view.** Original art direction, not a moodboard of this year's trends.
- **Directed motion.** Animation that paces the story and guides the eye — a pinned sequence, a considered page transition, one signature moment.
- **A respectful intro.** A roughly two-second branded reveal can set tone; a long progress bar is a usability penalty.
- **Mobile parity.** Jurors score on real laptops and mid-range phones, not workstations.
- **Real content.** Real copy, case studies and imagery; placeholder energy shows even at 10% weight.

What jurors penalize

- **Random effects:** everything floats and parallaxes, so nothing matters. The most common reason a creative site scores like an average one.
- **Jank:** a WebGL hero dropping to 20fps reads as broken, however beautiful the still frame.
- **Broken mobile:** a desktop masterpiece with a collapsed phone layout caps at an Honorable Mention.
- **Derivative concepts:** borrowing the trend of the moment costs creativity points directly.
- **No accessibility floor:** missing focus states, no reduced-motion path, low contrast, a custom cursor hiding the real one.

What this means for how you build

- Build the floor before the ceiling: typography, layout, speed and mobile first; the WebGL flourish last.
- WebGL is not required. Many Sites of the Day are CSS and GSAP with exceptional type and directed motion; a flawless 2D site beats a janky 3D one.
- Budget a dedicated polish phase for 60fps, mobile parity, reduced motion, focus states and fast first paint. That phase is where Honorable Mentions become Sites of the Day.
- Study winners, then close the tab before designing. Copying the current winner is the fastest way to lose creativity points. For calibration, recent Awwwards listings tag *Lando Norris* by OFF+BRAND and *Messenger* by abeto as Sites of the Year 2025 ([Awwwards listings](#)).

4. Concept and art direction

The gap between slop and an award site is decided before any code: a concept specific enough that the visual choices become inevitable. Run these six steps in order and show the output of steps 1–4 before building.

Step 1 — Extract the brief

Answer each in one line. If the user didn't say, propose an answer and flag it as an assumption.

- **Subject:** what is this, concretely? ("A 40-seat Kerala seafood restaurant in Bandra", not "a restaurant site")
- **Audience:** who arrives, from where, on what device, knowing what?
- **Primary job:** the one thing the page must get done (book a table, start a trial, hire the studio).
- **Primary action:** the single CTA that does that job.
- **Tone:** three words it should feel like, and three it must never feel like.
- **Proof:** what real evidence exists (numbers, clients, photos, press, product)?
- **Constraints:** brand assets, stack, performance budget, languages, accessibility requirements.

Step 2 — Find the concept

The concept is one sentence that ties the design to the subject's world. It must be specific enough to rule things out.

Subject	Weak concept	Strong concept	Decisions it forces
Specialty coffee roaster	"Warm and modern"	"The page is a roast curve: it darkens as you scroll from green bean to second crack"	Background and type color shift with scroll; temperature-chart data motif; roast-level tags as real data
Structural engineering firm	"Clean and professional"	"Show the load path"	Exposed grid lines that carry content like beams; diagrams over stock photos; restrained steel-and-concrete palette
Children's reading app	"Fun and colorful"	"Every page is a pop-up book"	Layered paper cutouts, parallax only on depth layers, chunky rounded type, tactile press states
Fintech for freelancers	"Trustworthy and sleek"	"Your money, itemized"	Receipt-like typography, tabular numerals as hero, ledger-line rhythm, real invoice examples

Step 3 — Generate three directions, then reject the median

Sketch three genuinely different directions (different type, palette and layout logic). Discard the one closest to what any model would make for this prompt. Choose between the other two by fit to the concept and the audience, not by novelty.

Direction	Suits	Risk
Swiss / International	Engineering, architecture, B2B, tools	Cold and generic if the grid has no tension
Editorial	Media, culture, fashion, studios, long-form	Becomes broadsheet cosplay if content isn't truly editorial

Direction	Suits	Risk
Expressive / maximal	Music, events, youth brands, campaigns	Noise and poor usability if there's no hierarchy
Neo-brutalist	Creative agencies, dev tools, counter-culture	Reads as unfinished; wrong for finance, health, enterprise
Organic / soft	Wellness, food, hospitality, sustainability	Drifts into bland beige
Technical / instrumented	Data, science, hardware, AI infrastructure	Fake data and mono labels become costume
Luxury / restrained	Hospitality, fashion, high-end products	Empty and slow if the photography isn't excellent
Playful / tactile	Consumer apps, kids, games, snacks	Childish or gimmicky for serious decisions

Step 4 — Write the compact token plan

- **Color:** four to six named values with a role each (name them after the subject: "Kiln Ash", "Harbor Rope").
- **Type:** families, their roles, the scale ratio, body size and measure.
- **Space and shape:** spacing base, section rhythm, radius personality, elevation levels.
- **Motion:** easing personality, duration range, the one orchestrated moment.
- **Layout:** the layout idea in one sentence plus an ASCII wireframe for the hero and two key sections, and an alignment rule (left axis, centered, asymmetric).
- **Principles:** three rules unique to this page ("numbers are always the biggest thing on screen").

Step 5 — Design the signature moment

Pick the one interaction or image people will screenshot and share. Define it precisely (what moves, when, why it expresses the concept), give it most of the performance budget, and keep everything around it quiet.

Step 6 — Review the plan against the brief and Part 2

For each token and layout decision, run the prompt-twin test. Revise anything that looks like the default for a similar page, and record what changed and why. Only then write code.

5. Typography

Type is the fastest signal of quality a juror or user reads: choose one or two families on purpose, set a real scale, and treat display type as an image rather than a delivery vehicle.

Choosing typefaces

- **Match shapes to the subject.** Geometric sans for precision and tech; grotesks for neutrality with edge; humanist sans for warmth and readability; transitional or old-style serifs for heritage and long reading; high-contrast didones for fashion and luxury; slab serifs for sturdiness; wide or condensed display cuts for impact.
- **Check the working range:** true italics, at least four weights (or a variable axis), tabular and old-style figures, the languages you need, optical sizes for display versus text, a web license.
- **One family is often enough.** Use size, weight and case for contrast. If you use two, make them clearly different (a serif display with a sans text, not two similar grotesks). Three families need a real reason.
- **Look beyond the defaults.** Commercial foundries with distinctive web-ready families include Klim, Grilli Type, Dinamo, Pangram Pangram, Commercial Type, Displaay and Production Type. Free, open-license sources with character include Velvetyne and Colletttivo. Fontshare and Google Fonts are useful, but their trending faces become the next default fast — see Part 2.

The scale

Context	Ratio	Feel
Dense product UI, dashboards	1.125–1.2	Calm, compact
Marketing sites, docs	1.25–1.333	Clear steps
Editorial, portfolios, campaigns	1.414–1.618+	Dramatic display sizes

- Body text: 16–20px (1–1.25rem), larger for editorial reading. Never below 16px for body on mobile.
- Line-height: 1.5–1.7 for body (serifs and long lines want more), 1.1–1.3 for subheads, 0.9–1.1 for large display.
- Measure: 45–75 characters, about 66 ideal; 40–50 in multi-column layouts. Set it with `max-inline-size: 65ch`, not a pixel width. (web.dev)
- Make it fluid with `clamp()`, and always mix `rem` with `vw` inside it so text still responds to browser zoom. ([Utopia](https://utopia.fyi))

```
:root {
  --step--1: clamp(0.83rem, 0.80rem + 0.15vw, 0.94rem);
  --step-0:  clamp(1.00rem, 0.95rem + 0.25vw, 1.19rem);
  --step-1:  clamp(1.25rem, 1.15rem + 0.50vw, 1.58rem);
  --step-2:  clamp(1.56rem, 1.38rem + 0.90vw, 2.11rem);
  --step-3:  clamp(1.95rem, 1.63rem + 1.60vw, 2.81rem);
  --step-4:  clamp(2.44rem, 1.90rem + 2.70vw, 3.75rem);
  --step-5:  clamp(3.05rem, 2.15rem + 4.50vw, 5.00rem);
  --step-6:  clamp(3.80rem, 2.30rem + 7.50vw, 8.00rem); /* hero display */
}
```

Setting display type

- Tighten tracking as size grows: roughly -0.01em at 32px to -0.04em at 96px and above. Loosen slightly for small text.
- `text-wrap: balance` on headings; `text-wrap: pretty` on paragraphs to avoid one-word last lines.
- Break headlines by meaning, not by container width. At display sizes, check every breakpoint for orphans and awkward splits.
- Use the type itself as the visual: extreme scale contrast, cropping at the viewport edge, overlapping images, variable-axis motion — but it must stay real, selectable text.

Details that separate professional from generic

- Real punctuation: curly quotes “ ” and apostrophes ’, en dash for ranges (9–5), em dash for breaks, a true ellipsis (...), × for dimensions.
- A non-breaking space between a number and its unit, and inside short names that must not split.

- `font-variant-numeric: tabular-nums` for prices, tables and counters; old-style figures inside editorial text.
- Hanging punctuation for pull quotes; optical margin alignment for large quotes.
- `hyphens: auto` for narrow justified or small columns, with the correct `lang` attribute.
- Underlined body links with `text-underline-offset` and `text-decoration-thickness` tuned to the face.

Loading fonts without hurting performance

- Self-host WOFF2, subset to the scripts you need, and prefer one variable file over many static weights.
- Preload only the one or two files used above the fold.
- `font-display: swap` for display faces; consider `optional` for body text on slow-network audiences.
- Define a fallback with `size-adjust`, `ascent-override` and `descent-override` so the swap doesn't shift layout.

Typography anti-patterns

- One word of the headline in a different color, italic or gradient.
- ALL-CAPS tracked labels above every section.
- Gradient-filled text; outlined text for body copy.
- Light-grey body text that fails contrast; 12–14px body copy.
- Centered paragraphs longer than two lines.
- More than three weights on one screen; faux bold or faux italic from missing files.

6. Color

Build color as a token system in OKLCH, derive it from the subject's world, and keep the accent scarce enough to mean something.

Why OKLCH

OKLCH (lightness, chroma, hue) is perceptually uniform: equal steps in lightness look equally bright across hues, which HSL and hex cannot promise. That makes ramps, dark mode and hover states predictable. It is supported in all modern browsers. ([Evil Martians](#), [Atmos](#))

The structure

1. **Neutral ramp:** 10–12 steps from near-white to near-black, tinted slightly toward the brand hue (chroma about 0.005–0.02). Pure grey reads as unconsidered.
2. **Brand hue(s):** one primary, optionally one secondary, each as a ramp with constant hue and lightness in even steps.
3. **Semantic colors:** success, warning, danger, info — each a ramp, adjusted so they sit comfortably with the brand hue.
4. **Role tokens:** components only ever use roles, never raw ramp values.

```
:root {
  /* ramps */
  --ink-50:   oklch(0.98 0.006 60);
  --ink-900:  oklch(0.22 0.012 60);
  --brand-500: oklch(0.62 0.16 35);
  /* roles */
  --bg: var(--ink-50);
  --surface: oklch(0.96 0.008 60);
  --text: var(--ink-900);
  --text-muted: oklch(0.45 0.012 60);
  --border: oklch(0.88 0.01 60);
  --accent: var(--brand-500);
  --on-accent: oklch(0.99 0.004 60);
  --focus: oklch(0.55 0.2 250);
}
```

Deriving a palette that isn't generic

- Pull colors from photography and materials of the subject's world: the actual product, its place, its packaging, its history.
- Name every color after its source. A named palette is a chosen palette.
- Decide the proportion up front. A starting heuristic is 60% dominant neutral, 30% secondary, 10% accent; award sites often go further, with one saturated color used almost nowhere.
- Consider a bold, non-white base (a deep color, a saturated field) when the concept supports it; the page background is the largest color decision you make.

Contrast rules

Element	WCAG 2.2 AA minimum
Body text	4.5:1
Large text (24px+, or 18.66px+ bold)	3:1
UI components, icons that carry meaning, focus indicators	3:1 against adjacent colors
Placeholder and disabled text	Placeholder must meet text contrast if it conveys information; disabled is exempt but should still be legible

- Use WCAG 2.x ratios for compliance. Use APCA as a perceptual cross-check, especially for thin weights and colored backgrounds (roughly Lc 75+ for body text, 90 preferred); it is not yet a legal requirement.
- Never carry meaning by color alone: pair it with an icon, label, pattern or position. Check palettes under deuteranopia, protanopia and tritanopia simulation.

Dark mode

- Design it, don't invert it. Base background around L 0.15–0.22, not pure black; lift elevated surfaces by lightness rather than shadows.
- Reduce chroma of accents and semantic colors so they don't vibrate on dark surfaces; re-test every contrast pair.
- Set `color-scheme: light dark` and use `light-dark()` or a `[data-theme]` switch; respect `prefers-color-scheme` by default and let users override.
- Images and illustrations may need dimmed or alternate versions.

Gradients and effects

- A gradient needs a reason: a light source, a material, a data range, a time of day. Decoration alone is a tell.
- Interpolate in OKLCH to avoid muddy grey midpoints: `linear-gradient(in oklch, var(--a), var(--b))`.
- Offer wide-gamut P3 accents only as an enhancement inside `@media (color-gamut: p3)`.

Color anti-patterns

- Indigo/violet as the default accent; purple-to-blue gradients; neon glows on dark backgrounds everywhere.
- A different accent color per section with no system.
- Tinted near-black (`#0B0B0B` , `#111`) chosen out of habit rather than as a considered base.
- Muted grey text below 4.5:1 for anything people need to read.

7. Layout, grid, spacing and composition

A layout reads as designed when space encodes relationships, the grid has tension, and the rhythm changes from section to section.

Spacing system

- One scale on a 4px base: 4, 8, 12, 16, 24, 32, 48, 64, 96, 128, 160. Nothing off-scale without a stated reason.
- **Proximity rule:** space inside a group is at most half the space between groups. If a label is as far from its field as from the next field, the form is broken.
- Section spacing is fluid and varied, e.g. `padding-block: clamp(4rem, 10vw, 10rem)` , with some sections deliberately tighter or looser to create rhythm.
- Use `gap` for spacing within flex and grid layouts; avoid margin stacks that collapse unpredictably.

Grid

- A 12-column grid on desktop (4 on mobile, 8 on tablet) with 16–32px gutters and fluid outer margins, e.g. `clamp(1rem, 5vw, 5rem)` .
- Content max-width around 1200–1440px, but text columns capped at about 65ch inside it.
- Use CSS Grid with named lines or areas; use `subgrid` so card internals (titles, prices, buttons) align across a row.
- Break the grid on purpose: an image bleeding off the edge, a headline spanning into the margin, an offset column. Breaking only works when the grid is otherwise strict.

Composition moves that create quality

- **Scale contrast:** one very large element against small, precise details. Timid size differences read as template.
- **Asymmetry with an axis:** a strong alignment line (usually the left text edge) that many elements share, with weight distributed unevenly around it.
- **Negative space as a shape:** leave whole grid regions empty on purpose, especially around the signature element.
- **Layering and overlap:** type over image, image over color field, elements crossing section boundaries — with contrast checked.
- **Bold crops:** crop photography tightly around what matters; vary crop and aspect ratio within one art-directed family.
- **Full-bleed versus contained:** alternate edge-to-edge moments with contained ones to give the page a pulse.

Hierarchy checks

- One focal point per viewport. If two things shout, one must whisper.
- Squint or blur the screenshot: the order of importance should survive.
- Scanning follows F- and Z-patterns: put the most important words at the start of lines and headings, and the primary action on the natural exit point of the eye path.
- Left-align text by default. Center only short display lines and isolated statements.

Heroes that aren't the default

The hero must answer three things: what this is, why it matters to me, what to do next.
Formats beyond "centered headline + two buttons":

- The product itself, working (an interactive demo, a real screenshot in motion, a configurator).
- Type as image: one oversized statement cropped by the viewport.
- Editorial split: a strong image on one side, an asymmetric text block on the other.
- The subject's most characteristic object, photographed or rendered, with minimal text.
- A number or fact as the hero, only when that number is genuinely the story.

Shape, depth and radius

- Pick a radius personality (sharp, small, large) and scale it by element size. Nested radius = outer radius minus the padding between them.
- Three or four elevation levels at most. Layer shadows (a tight contact shadow plus a soft ambient one), tint them toward the background hue, and use them only where something is truly above something else.
- Borders at low contrast separate; they don't decorate. Prefer spacing over lines where possible.

Layout anti-patterns

- The same "centered heading + three cards" module repeated down the page.
- Bento grids for content that isn't modular or doesn't vary in importance.
- Everything boxed in cards, including things that are just text.
- Uniform padding everywhere, so nothing groups.
- Full-width text lines on large screens.

8. Imagery, iconography, illustration and 3D

Original, art-directed imagery is the single biggest visual gap between template sites and award sites; when you can't get it, use fewer images, not worse ones.

Photography

- Real photographs of the actual product, people and place beat any stock library. If the brief has none, ask for them before designing around placeholders.
- Art-direct the set: one lighting mood, one color grade, a consistent subject distance, a small family of aspect ratios.
- Stock only when it's genuinely indistinguishable from commissioned work; never handshakes, headsets, laptops on beaches or diverse-team-pointing-at-screen.
- AI-generated imagery: avoid it for real people and real products (trust and uncanny details). If used for abstract or atmospheric work, direct it tightly and keep one consistent style.

Product and interface imagery

- Show the real interface, cropped to the part that matters, at a size where it can be read. Annotate what the user should notice.
- Animate real flows (a short screen recording or a coded demo) instead of floating fake dashboards in 3D perspective.
- Never invent metrics inside screenshots.

Icons

- One family, one stroke weight, one corner style, sized to the text they sit beside (typically aligned to cap height).
- Label icons unless they're universal (search, close, menu, play). Icon-only buttons need an accessible name.
- No emoji as interface icons. No icon above every paragraph just to fill space.

Illustration

- Custom illustration tied to the concept, or none. A single consistent style across the whole site.
- Avoid the generic flat-people style and blob backgrounds that signal template kits.

3D and WebGL

- Use it only when it expresses the concept (the product has form, the data has space, the story needs depth). WebGL helps creativity scores only when it holds 60fps.
- Cap device pixel ratio at 2, pause rendering when off-screen or the tab is hidden, and lazy-load the scene after first paint.
- Compress: Draco or meshopt for geometry, KTX2/Basis for textures; keep the initial scene small and stream detail.
- Always provide a static fallback image and a reduced-motion version; never gate content behind the canvas.
- Test on a mid-range Android phone, not just a laptop.
- Tools: Three.js or React Three Fiber for most work; WebGPU where supported for heavy scenes; Spline for fast prototypes (watch its payload size).

Video

- Decorative loops: muted, `playsinline`, short, compressed (AV1 or HEVC with an H.264 fallback), with a lightweight poster frame.
- Anything moving for more than five seconds needs a visible pause control (WCAG 2.2.2).
- Content video needs captions and, for key information, a transcript.

Delivering images

- AVIF or WebP with fallback via `<picture>`; responsive `srcset` and accurate `sizes`.
- Always set `width` and `height` (or `aspect-ratio`) so space is reserved and layout doesn't shift.
- The hero (LCP) image: `fetchpriority="high"`, never `loading="lazy"`. Everything below the fold: `loading="lazy"` and `decoding="async"`.
- Alt text states the image's purpose in context; decorative images get `alt=""`.

Texture

Grain, noise and paper textures work when the concept is material (print, film, craft). Use a small static tile at low opacity; never a full-screen animated noise canvas that burns battery for nothing.

9. Motion and interaction

Motion earns its place only when it explains, responds or directs; one orchestrated moment beats a hundred decorative fades, and all of it must run at 60fps.

The purpose test

Every animation must do at least one of these, or it goes:

1. **Feedback:** confirms an action happened (press, toggle, copy, save).
2. **State change:** shows what changed (open, expand, select, reorder).
3. **Spatial continuity:** shows where something came from or went (a card expanding into a page).
4. **Attention:** points at the one thing that matters now.
5. **Narrative pacing:** the single orchestrated sequence that tells the story (page load, a pinned scroll chapter).

The frequency rule

Match motion to how often it's seen. Keyboard-triggered and very frequent actions (command palettes, list navigation, tab switches) get no animation. Actions seen tens of times a day get minimal motion. Occasional moments get standard motion. Once-per-visit moments (the intro, the signature sequence) can be expressive. ([Emil Kowalski](#))

Timing

Duration	Use	Examples
100–150ms	Instant feedback	Button press, toggle, color change
200–300ms	State changes	Menu open, tooltip, hover response
300–500ms	Layout changes	Accordion, modal, drawer
500–800ms	Entrances	Page load sequence, hero reveal

Exits run faster than entrances (about 75% of the entry time). Larger distances need slightly longer durations; the same duration on a bigger move feels rushed.

Easing

- Never the default `ease`, and never `linear` for movement (except scroll-scrubbed timelines and continuous rotation).
- Entering: strong ease-out, e.g. `cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1)`.
- Exiting: ease-in, e.g. `cubic-bezier(0.7, 0, 0.84, 0)`.
- Toggles that go there and back: ease-in-out, e.g. `cubic-bezier(0.65, 0, 0.35, 1)`.
- Gestures, drags and anything the user can interrupt: springs.

Physicality

- Scale from 0.95 with opacity, never from 0. Nothing in the real world appears from a point.
- Set `transform-origin` at the trigger: a popover grows from its button, a menu from its corner.
- Stagger groups by 30–60ms and cap the stagger at six to eight items; long lists appear together.
- Pressed buttons scale to about 0.97 on `:active` for tactile response.

Performance

- Animate `transform` and `opacity` only; they skip layout and paint. Never animate `width`, `height`, `top`, `left`, `margin` or `box-shadow` on scroll.
- Use `will-change` only just before an animation runs, never globally.
- Prefer CSS transitions or the Web Animations API for fixed motion; they stay smooth when the main thread is busy.
- Run one animation clock. With GSAP and Lenis, drive both from the GSAP ticker instead of competing `requestAnimationFrame` loops. ([Hon Tran](#))
- Make state animations interruptible: transitions (not keyframes) for anything that can reverse mid-way.

Scroll

- Native CSS scroll-driven animations (`animation-timeline: view() / scroll()`) are cheap and smooth; wrap them in `@supports` and provide a static fallback.
- GSAP ScrollTrigger for complex pinned, scrubbed sequences.
- Smooth-scroll libraries (Lenis) only if anchor links, keyboard scrolling, find-in-page and scroll restoration still work, and they're disabled for reduced motion.
- Never change scroll speed or direction on content-heavy pages; scroll-jacking fails usability.
- Reveal-on-scroll must not hide content from people who arrive by anchor link, search or print.

Page transitions

- The View Transitions API gives native, cheap transitions. Same-document transitions are safe to ship; cross-document (multi-page) transitions are progressive enhancement: unsupported browsers get an instant cut. ([alexcloudstar](#))
- Keep page transitions under about 400ms, and never delay navigation for them.

Hover, cursor and intro

- Gate hover effects with `@media (hover: hover) and (pointer: fine)`. Nothing essential lives only on hover.
- A custom cursor may add character on desktop, but never hide the native cursor's function, and switch it off on touch and reduced motion.

- Intros and preloaders: about two seconds of branded reveal at most, and never hide the hero headline behind JavaScript, because hidden text delays the largest contentful paint.

Reduced motion

`prefers-reduced-motion: reduce` means replace spatial movement with simple fades or instant changes, not break the page. Keep functional motion (progress indicators, focus changes). Stop parallax, auto-playing loops and scroll-scrubbed movement.

```
@media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce) {
  *, *::before, *::after {
    animation-duration: 0.01ms !important;
    animation-iteration-count: 1 !important;
    transition-duration: 0.01ms !important;
    scroll-behavior: auto !important;
  }
}
```

Motion anti-patterns

- Fade-and-slide-up on every section; hover-lift on every card.
- Parallax on everything; infinite marquees used as filler.
- Typewriter headlines; numbers counting up to invented stats.
- Animated gradient backgrounds that never stop.
- Motion on keyboard shortcuts and high-frequency actions.

10. Components and states

A site feels finished when every component handles every state; AI output usually ships the default state only.

The state matrix

Every interactive element: **default**, **hover**, **focus-visible**, **active/pressed**, **selected**, **disabled**, **loading**. Every view or data region: **loading (skeleton)**, **empty**, **partial**, **error**, **success**, **offline**. If a state isn't designed, it isn't done.

Component rules

Component	Must have	Common failure
Primary button	Verb-first label naming the outcome; one per view; min 44px tall; loading state that keeps its width	"Submit", "Learn more" x6, spinner that makes it jump
Secondary / tertiary buttons	Clearly lower emphasis (outline, text); consistent order across flows	Two equally loud buttons competing
Text links	Underlined in body text; distinct visited state where useful	Links identifiable only by color
Header / nav	Current page indicated; logo links home; skip link; sticky only if useful, hide on scroll down, show on scroll up	Sticky bar covering focused elements
Mega menu / dropdown	Opens on click (hover as an enhancement), closes on Esc and outside click, keyboard navigable	Hover-only menus that vanish on diagonal mouse paths
Dialog / modal	Native <code><dialog></code> or real focus trap; Esc closes; focus returns to trigger; body scroll locked	Opening on page load; no close button; focus lost behind it
Drawer / bottom sheet	Swipe and button to close; visible handle on mobile	Gesture-only dismissal
Toast	Polite live region; errors stay until dismissed; undo for destructive actions	Errors that vanish in 3 seconds
Tooltip	Supplementary only; shows on hover and focus; never holds essential info	The only place a critical instruction lives
Tabs	Arrow-key navigation; selected state clear; content not hidden from search if important	Tabs used to hide primary content

Component	Must have	Common failure
Accordion	Whole header clickable; state icon; <code><details></code> where possible	Only the tiny chevron is clickable
Cards	One primary link covering the card via a pseudo-element; no nested competing links	Entire card a link with buttons inside it
Tables	Numbers right-aligned with tabular figures; sticky header; sortable columns marked; a mobile strategy	Squashed columns on mobile
Carousel	Visible controls, pause, swipe, no autoplay; never the only place key content lives	Auto-rotating hero slider
Search	Visible field (not just an icon) on content-heavy sites; suggestions; forgiving of typos; useful empty results	"No results" with no next step
Pagination / infinite list	Keeps position on back navigation; a real footer remains reachable	Infinite scroll that hides the footer forever
Footer	Real sitemap, contact, legal, social; designed, not an afterthought	Copyright line and three icons

Loading, empty and error

- **Under ~300ms:** show nothing (a flash of spinner feels slower).
- **300ms–2s:** skeleton screens shaped like the real content, or an inline spinner in the triggering control.
- **Over 2s:** progress with meaning (steps, percentage, what's happening); let people keep working.
- **Optimistic UI** for likes, saves and toggles: update immediately, reconcile quietly, show an error with undo if it fails.
- **Empty states:** say what will appear here and give the one action that fills it. Never a blank area or a sad illustration alone.

- **Errors:** what happened, why (if known), and how to fix it, next to where it happened. Keep the user's input.

The detail pass

- Custom `::selection` color, visible `:focus-visible` ring, `accent-color` for native checkboxes and radios, styled scrollbars only if they stay usable.
- Favicon set, touch icon, social share image per key page, a designed 404 page with a way forward.
- Consistent icon sizes and optical centering of icons in buttons; checked alignment of text baselines across columns.

11. UX foundations

Innovate in presentation, stay conventional in interaction: people spend most of their time on other sites and expect yours to work the same way.

Nielsen's ten heuristics, applied

Heuristic	What it means on a website
Visibility of system status	Loading, saving, sending and errors are always shown; current page is marked
Match with the real world	Labels in the user's words, not internal jargon or system names
User control and freedom	Undo, back, cancel and close always work; no dead ends
Consistency and standards	Same component, same behavior; follow platform conventions
Error prevention	Constraints, good defaults, confirmation for destructive actions
Recognition over recall	Options visible, recent items remembered, examples in fields
Flexibility and efficiency	Shortcuts and search for experts without burdening novices

Heuristic	What it means on a website
Aesthetic and minimalist design	Every element competes for attention; remove what doesn't earn it
Help users recover from errors	Plain-language errors that say how to fix the problem
Help and documentation	Findable, task-focused help in a consistent place

Laws of UX worth designing with

Law	Design implication
Jakob's law	Users expect your site to work like the others they use; keep navigation, forms and checkout conventional
Fitts's law	Important targets large and close to where the pointer or thumb already is
Hick's law	More choices, slower decisions; reduce and group options, highlight a recommended one
Miller's law	Chunk information into small groups; don't treat "7 items" as a hard UI limit
Doherty threshold	Respond within about 400ms or show progress, or attention drifts
Aesthetic-usability effect	Beautiful interfaces are perceived as easier, which buys tolerance but hides real problems in testing
Von Restorff effect	The one different item is remembered; make the primary action the only one styled that way
Serial position effect	First and last items are remembered best; put key nav items at the ends
Peak-end rule	People judge an experience by its peak and its end; design the signature moment and the confirmation screen with care

Law	Design implication
Goal-gradient effect	Motivation rises near completion; show progress in multi-step flows
Zeigarnik effect	Incomplete tasks stick; progress indicators and saved drafts bring people back
Tesler's law	Complexity can't vanish, only move; absorb it in the system, not the user
Gestalt: proximity, similarity, common region	Grouping is communicated by space, shared styling and shared containers

Information architecture and navigation

- Start from a content inventory and the top tasks users come to do; structure around those, not the org chart.
- Keep top-level navigation to a handful of clearly worded items; put the primary CTA in the header.
- Show navigation on desktop. In NN/g's study of 179 users, hidden navigation was less discoverable and slower to use on both desktop and mobile, with the worst effects on desktop. ([NN/g](#))
- On mobile, a menu button is acceptable; for app-like sites, a bottom tab bar for the top four or five destinations is better.
- Portfolio and campaign sites with very few pages can use a full-screen menu as a creative moment — but keep the primary action visible outside it.
- Mark the current location, add breadcrumbs for deep hierarchies, and offer search on large sites.

Landing-page clarity

- **The five-second test:** a stranger can say what it is, who it's for and what to do next.
- People do scroll, but the first viewport sets whether they will. It should answer the core question and visibly invite the scroll.
- Proof must be specific: named customers, real quotes with names and roles, concrete numbers with context.
- Answer objections before they're raised: pricing clarity, FAQ, guarantees, security, what happens after signup.

Ethics: never use dark patterns

No confirmshaming, forced continuity, hidden costs, fake urgency or scarcity, pre-ticked consent, roach-motel cancellations, or cookie banners where rejecting is harder than accepting. They damage trust, invite regulation, and jurors notice.

Research, even on a budget

- Test with about five users per round and iterate; a few rounds catch most major problems.
- Watch real sessions, read search logs and support tickets, and measure task completion, not just clicks.
- A/B test decisions that matter, with enough traffic to be meaningful.

12. Forms and UX writing

Forms are where designs quietly fail, and words are design material: both get the same care as the hero.

Form rules

1. **One column.** Multi-column forms get misread; pair fields only when they form a natural unit (expiry + CVC), and stack them on mobile. ([Baymard](#))
2. **Labels above fields, always visible.** Never use the placeholder as the label: in Baymard's testing, labels that disappear on typing caused severe problems, especially when fixing errors. ([Baymard](#))
3. **Fewer fields.** Every field must earn its place. Hide optional ones behind a link, prefill what you can, and don't split single inputs like phone numbers.
4. **Mark required and optional explicitly.** Don't rely on a lone asterisk.
5. **Right input for the job:** correct `type`, `inputmode` and `autocomplete` attributes so mobile keyboards and password managers help. Allow paste everywhere.
6. **Input masks** for restricted formats (phone, card, date), localized to the user.
7. **Validate on blur, not per keystroke** — except password strength, character limits and username availability, which benefit from live feedback.
8. **Specific error messages beside the field**, plus a summary at the top on submit that links to each error. Keep everything the user typed.

9. **The submit button names the outcome:** "Create account", "Pay ₹1,499", "Send message".
10. **Multi-step flows** show progress, allow going back without data loss, and never ask for the same information twice (WCAG 3.3.7).
11. **Authentication without puzzles:** allow password managers and paste, offer passkeys or magic links, avoid CAPTCHAs where possible (WCAG 3.3.8).
12. **Confirmation screens** say what happened, what happens next and when.

Writing the interface

- **Headlines say what it is and for whom.** Specific beats clever: nouns, numbers, names.
- **CTAs are verb + object** and keep one name through the flow: the "Publish" button produces a "Published" toast.
- **Sentence case** for headings and buttons; active voice; one job per sentence.
- **Name things by what users understand**, not how the system is built: "notifications", not "webhook config".
- **Errors never apologize or blame**, and are never vague: what went wrong, how to fix it.
- **Empty states invite action:** what goes here and the one button that starts it.
- **Helper text before errors:** show the format or rule up front instead of punishing people after.
- **Readability:** aim for a grade 7–9 reading level for general audiences; front-load the key words in every line, heading and link.
- **Three tone words** from the brief govern every string, from the hero to the 404 page.

Words to cut

Unlock, elevate, supercharge, revolutionize, empower, seamless, effortless, cutting-edge, robust, leverage, game-changing, next-level, "all-in-one", "reimagined", "built for the way you work". If a sentence still makes sense with the adjective removed, remove it.

Before and after

Generic	Specific
Unlock the power of seamless invoicing	Send an invoice in 40 seconds. Get paid in 2 days, not 30.

Generic	Specific
Learn more	See pricing for teams of 10
Submit	Book table for 4
Oops! Something went wrong.	We couldn't charge this card. Check the expiry date or try another card.
No data	No invoices yet. Create your first one — it takes a minute.

13. Accessibility: the WCAG 2.2 AA floor

WCAG 2.2 AA is the floor, not the goal: it is the version most new regulations and procurement now cite, and jurors read missing focus states and reduced-motion paths as carelessness.

What WCAG 2.2 added

WCAG 2.2 became a W3C Recommendation in October 2023, added nine success criteria and retired 4.1.1 Parsing. ([Somerset playbook](#), [PowerMapper](#))

Criterion	Level	What to do
2.4.11 Focus Not Obscured (Minimum)	AA	Sticky headers, cookie bars and chat widgets must not fully cover the focused element; use <code>scroll-padding-top</code>
2.4.12 Focus Not Obscured (Enhanced)	AAA	No part of the focused element is covered
2.4.13 Focus Appearance	AAA	A thick, high-contrast focus indicator
2.5.7 Dragging Movements	AA	Every drag action has a single-pointer alternative (buttons, click-to-place)
2.5.8 Target Size (Minimum)	AA	Targets at least 24×24 CSS px, or enough spacing around smaller ones
3.2.6 Consistent Help	A	Help and contact links appear in the same place on every page

Criterion	Level	What to do
3.3.7 Redundant Entry	A	Don't make people re-enter information they already gave in the same process
3.3.8 Accessible Authentication (Minimum)	AA	No memory or puzzle tests to log in; allow paste and password managers
3.3.9 Accessible Authentication (Enhanced)	AAA	No cognitive tests at all, including object recognition

The checklist

Perceivable

- ☐ Text contrast 4.5:1; large text 3:1; UI components and focus indicators 3:1.
- ☐ Meaningful images have alt text that states their purpose; decorative ones have `alt=""`.
- ☐ Video has captions; audio has transcripts.
- ☐ Information isn't conveyed by color, shape or position alone.
- ☐ Content reflows at 320 CSS px wide without horizontal scrolling; text resizes to 200% without loss.
- ☐ Layout survives user text-spacing overrides (line-height 1.5, letter-spacing 0.12em).

Operable

- ☐ Everything works with a keyboard alone, in a logical order, with no traps.
- ☐ A visible `:focus-visible` style on every interactive element (a 2px+ outline with offset is a safe default).
- ☐ A "Skip to content" link as the first focusable element.
- ☐ Targets at least 24×24px; aim for 44×44px on touch.
- ☐ Anything that moves, blinks or auto-updates for more than five seconds can be paused.
- ☐ Nothing flashes more than three times per second.
- ☐ `prefers-reduced-motion` is respected.
- ☐ Descriptive page titles; link text that makes sense out of context (no bare "click here").

Understandable

- ☐ `<html lang>` set, and `lang` on passages in other languages.

- ☐ Labels and instructions on every input; errors identified in text with a fix suggested.
- ☐ Navigation and components behave consistently across pages.

Robust

- ☐ Semantic HTML first: landmarks (`header` , `nav` , `main` , `footer`), one `h1` , headings in order, real lists, `button` for actions and `a` for navigation.
- ☐ ARIA only where native HTML can't express it: `aria-expanded` , `aria-controls` , `aria-current` , live regions for async updates.
- ☐ Custom widgets follow the ARIA Authoring Practices keyboard patterns.

How to test

1. Automated scan (axe, Lighthouse) — useful, but it misses many issues that only manual testing finds.
2. Unplug the mouse and complete every key task by keyboard.
3. Run a screen reader (VoiceOver on Mac/iOS, NVDA on Windows, TalkBack on Android) through the main flow.
4. Zoom to 200% and 400%; check a 320px-wide viewport.
5. Turn on reduced motion and high-contrast/forced-colors mode.

Legal context in one line: WCAG 2.2 AA is the reference for most current accessibility law and procurement, including in the EU, where the European Accessibility Act has applied since June 2025.

14. Performance and the modern CSS toolkit

Speed is part of the design: a slow first paint colors a juror's whole impression, and Google grades real users at the 75th percentile, mobile and desktop separately.

Core Web Vitals targets

Metric	Measures	Good	Poor
LCP — Largest Contentful Paint	Loading	≤ 2.5s	> 4.0s
INP — Interaction to Next Paint	Responsiveness	≤ 200ms	> 500ms
CLS — Cumulative Layout Shift	Visual stability	≤ 0.1	> 0.25

INP replaced FID in March 2024. Scores come from real Chrome users over the previous 28 days. Claims that Google tightened LCP to 2.0s are false; the published threshold is still 2.5s. ([Metadigital](#), [rgb.ir](#))

Fixing LCP

- Server-render or pre-render the first view; serve from a CDN.
- Give the hero image `fetchpriority="high"`, correct `sizes`, a modern format, and never lazy-load it.
- Preload the one or two critical font files.
- Don't hide the hero headline behind a preloader or a JavaScript reveal. Text at `opacity: 0` isn't painted, so it delays LCP.
- Dynamically import heavy modules (WebGL, animation libraries) after first paint.

Fixing INP

- Break up long tasks; yield to the main thread in heavy handlers.
- Keep event handlers light; debounce input work; move heavy work to web workers.
- Audit third-party scripts (tag managers, chat widgets, A/B tools); load them late or not at all.
- Prefer CSS and compositor-driven animation over JavaScript per-frame work.

Fixing CLS

- `width / height` or `aspect-ratio` on every image, video, iframe and embed.
- Reserve space for banners, ads and late-loading components; never insert content above what the user is reading.
- Use font fallback metric overrides so the web-font swap doesn't reflow text.
- Animate with `transform`, never with layout properties.

Budgets to hold

Pick explicit budgets and check them weekly on a real mid-range phone: for a marketing page, a sensible starting point is under ~200KB of compressed JavaScript before interaction, a hero image under ~200KB, no more than two to four font files, and a first view that renders without waiting on any third-party script.

The modern CSS toolkit

Use the platform before a library. Always check current support on Baseline or caniuse before relying on a feature, and ship newer ones behind `@supports` as enhancements.

Feature	Use it for	Stance
<code>clamp()</code> , <code>min()</code> , <code>max()</code>	Fluid type and spacing	Safe everywhere
Container queries (<code>@container</code> , <code>cqi</code>)	Components that adapt to their slot, not the viewport	Safe
<code>:has()</code>	Parent and state styling without JavaScript	Safe
<code>subgrid</code>	Aligning card internals across a row	Safe
<code>oklch()</code> , <code>color-mix()</code>	Perceptual color ramps and states	Safe
Relative color syntax (<code>oklch(from var(--c) ...)</code>)	Deriving hover and muted colors from one token	Check support; provide fallback values
<code>text-wrap: balance</code> / <code>pretty</code>	Headline and paragraph wrapping	Enhancement; harmless where unsupported
<code><dialog></code> , Popover API	Modals, menus, tooltips with built-in accessibility	Safe
<code>@starting-style</code> + <code>transition-behavior: allow-discrete</code>	Entry animations from <code>display: none</code>	Enhancement
View Transitions (same-document)	Animated state changes	Safe to ship
View Transitions (cross-document)	Animated multi-page navigation	Progressive enhancement
Scroll-driven animations (<code>animation-timeline</code>)	Scroll reveals and progress without JavaScript	Enhancement behind <code>@supports</code>
Anchor positioning	Tooltips and popovers tethered to triggers	Enhancement with a fallback position

Feature	Use it for	Stance
Cascade layers (<code>@layer</code>), nesting	Predictable specificity and organization	Safe
Logical properties (<code>margin-inline</code> , <code>padding-block</code>)	Right-to-left and vertical writing support	Safe
<code>svh</code> , <code>dvh</code> , <code>lvh</code> units	Full-height sections on mobile browsers	Safe; replace <code>100vh</code>

Engineering hygiene that jurors and users feel

- Semantic, valid HTML; meaningful `title` and meta description per page; Open Graph image; canonical URL; `sitemap.xml` ; structured data where it applies.
- No console errors, no 404s for assets, no layout breaking at in-between widths.
- CSS specificity kept flat (layers, low-specificity selectors) so section spacing and component styles don't fight each other.
- Respect user settings: `prefers-reduced-motion` , `prefers-color-scheme` , `prefers-contrast` , `forced-colors` .

15. Responsive and mobile

Most visitors arrive on a phone and jurors open sites on mid-range phones, so the small screen gets its own composition rather than a squashed desktop.

Principles

- **Design the phone layout deliberately**, then the desktop; decide what the signature moment becomes on a small screen instead of hiding it.
- **Breakpoints follow content**, not device names. Check every width between 320 and 1920px by dragging the window, not just 375/768/1440.
- **Components respond to their container** (container queries) so a card works in a sidebar and a full-width grid alike.
- **Large screens get composition, not stretched text**: cap line length, scale display type up, use the extra width for asymmetry and space.

Touch and thumbs

- Primary actions live in the bottom half of the screen or in a sticky bottom bar on long product and checkout pages.
- Targets at least 44×44px with 8px or more between adjacent ones.
- No function depends on hover; every swipe gesture has a visible button alternative.
- Input font size at least 16px so iOS doesn't zoom on focus; use the right `inputmode` for number, email and phone fields.

Mobile-specific CSS

- Replace `100vh` with `100svh` or `100dvh` to avoid the browser-toolbar jump.
- Respect notches and home indicators with `env(safe-area-inset-*)` and `viewport-fit=cover`.
- Prevent horizontal overflow: `overflow-x: clip` on the page wrapper as a safety net, but fix the element that overflows.
- Art-direct images with `<picture>` and `media` so crops work in portrait, not just scale down.

Performance on real phones

- Test on a real mid-range Android over a throttled network; laptops hide INP and GPU problems.
- Cap canvas pixel ratio at 2, reduce particle counts and shader complexity on small screens, and pause off-screen work.
- Ship less JavaScript to mobile: lazy-load below-the-fold interactivity.

Mobile navigation

- A menu button is acceptable on phones, labelled and at least 44px; keep the primary CTA visible outside it.
- Full-screen menus: large type, clear current item, easy close, focus trapped while open.
- For app-like products, a bottom tab bar for the four or five top destinations beats a hidden menu.

16. Page-type playbooks

The right level of expressiveness depends on the job: a portfolio can spend its whole budget on one experience, a checkout must spend almost none of it.

SaaS and product landing pages

- **Job:** make a stranger understand the product and start a trial or demo.
- **Must-haves:** a hero that shows the real product working; a headline naming the outcome for a specific audience; proof from named customers; pricing or a clear path to it; objection-handling FAQ; one repeated primary CTA.
- **Signature opportunity:** an interactive demo or a scroll sequence that walks through the core workflow using the real UI.
- **Pitfalls:** floating fake dashboards, feature grids of identical cards, logo walls of companies that don't use you.

Portfolios and studio sites

- **Job:** make the right client or employer feel the taste and hire.
- **Must-haves:** work first and big; case studies with the problem, the thinking and the result; a clear way to get in touch; fast project-to-project navigation.
- **Signature opportunity:** the most expressive moment on the web is allowed here — custom page transitions, a WebGL index, typographic play — as long as it holds 60fps and works on phones.
- **Pitfalls:** long preloaders, hidden navigation with no way back, case studies that are only images.

E-commerce

- **Job:** help people choose with confidence and pay without friction.
- **Must-haves:** large zoomable product imagery from several angles; price, variants and stock obvious; delivery cost and dates before checkout; reviews with real detail; guest checkout; single-column checkout with few fields.
- **Signature opportunity:** product storytelling pages (materials, making, use) that sit around, not inside, the purchase path.
- **Pitfalls:** motion inside the checkout, hidden costs, required account creation, custom dropdowns that break on mobile.

Editorial and content sites

- **Job:** make reading a pleasure and lead to the next story.
- **Must-haves:** a real text measure, generous leading, strong typographic hierarchy, clear bylines and dates, related stories, fast pages.
- **Signature opportunity:** art-directed feature stories with scroll-paced images, data graphics and pull quotes.
- **Pitfalls:** interstitials, autoplay video, sticky elements eating the reading area.

Dashboards and app UI

- **Job:** let people see status and act quickly, many times a day.
- **Must-haves:** dense but calm type scale (1.125–1.2), tabular numbers, clear empty and loading states, keyboard shortcuts, consistent layout across screens.
- **Signature opportunity:** craft in the micro-interactions and data visualization, not in decoration.
- **Pitfalls:** animation on frequent actions, low-contrast grey-on-grey, charts without labels or units.

Restaurants, hotels and local businesses

- **Job:** book, call, visit.
- **Must-haves:** booking, hours, address with map, phone and menu as real text (not a PDF) reachable within one tap on mobile.
- **Signature opportunity:** atmosphere through photography and type that evokes the place.
- **Pitfalls:** a cinematic intro between a hungry person and the menu.

Events and campaign microsites

- **Job:** create desire and drive registration or sharing in a short window.
- **Must-haves:** date, place, price and CTA instantly visible; a share image; add-to-calendar.
- **Signature opportunity:** full expressive range — bold type, motion, sound as opt-in — because the audience comes for the experience.
- **Pitfalls:** heavy pages that fail on event-day mobile networks.

Documentation

- **Job:** get people to the answer fast.
- **Must-haves:** excellent search, persistent sidebar navigation, copyable code blocks, clear versioning, on-page table of contents.
- **Signature opportunity:** interactive examples that run in the page.
- **Pitfalls:** marketing-style layouts, tiny code fonts, broken anchor links.

17. The critique protocol and ship checklist

Nothing ships until it has been looked at as a juror would look at it: score it, list the fixes by impact, fix them, and look again.

The critique loop

1. **Screenshot** the page at 375px, 768px and 1440px (full page and first viewport). If you can't render, say so and critique the code against this list instead.
2. **Squint test:** blur each screenshot. Is there one focal point per viewport and a clear order of importance?
3. **Five-second test:** from the first viewport alone, can you say what this is, who it's for and what to do next?
4. **Slop scan:** go through every item in Part 2. Each hit is a finding.
5. **Score** the page with the rubric below, as a harsh juror would.
6. **Write findings** as a table: issue, where, why it matters, fix, impact (high/medium/low).
7. **Fix high-impact items first**, then re-screenshot and re-score. Repeat until every criterion reaches 8.
8. **Remove one accessory:** delete the weakest decorative element and check the page got better.

Scoring rubric

Criterion	Weight	Questions a juror asks	Ship at
Design	40%	Is there a real art direction? Is the type scale deliberate and the hierarchy obvious? Is spacing consistent and grouping clear? Is every page as considered as the home page?	≥ 8/10

Criterion	Weight	Questions a juror asks	Ship at
Usability	30%	Can a stranger navigate without thinking? Is it fast on a phone? Are focus, contrast, targets and reduced motion handled? Does anything jank?	≥ 8/10
Creativity	20%	Is the concept specific to this subject? Is there one memorable moment? Would the prompt-twin look different?	≥ 7/10
Content	10%	Is the copy specific and in one voice? Are images real and art-directed? Is there any placeholder left?	≥ 8/10

Ship checklist

Concept and content

- ☐ One-sentence concept written, and every major choice traces back to it
- ☐ No placeholder text, names, logos, stats or stock clichés
- ☐ Headline passes the five-second test; CTAs are verb + object

Visual

- ☐ Type scale, spacing scale, color roles and radii come from tokens
- ☐ Headlines wrap well at every width; no orphans
- ☐ No Part 2 tells remain, first- or second-order
- ☐ Dark mode (if offered) designed and contrast-checked separately

Interaction

- ☐ Every interactive element has hover, focus-visible, active, disabled and loading states
- ☐ Every view has empty, error and success states
- ☐ Motion passes the purpose and frequency tests; transform/opacity only; 60fps on a mid-range phone
- ☐ Reduced-motion version works and nothing essential is lost

Accessibility

- ☐ Contrast 4.5:1 text, 3:1 large text and UI
- ☐ Full keyboard pass; skip link; focus never hidden by sticky elements
- ☐ Targets ≥ 24px (44px on touch); semantic landmarks and heading order

- ☐ Screen reader pass through the primary flow

Performance

- ☐ LCP ≤ 2.5s, INP ≤ 200ms, CLS ≤ 0.1 on a throttled mobile profile
- ☐ Hero image prioritized and not lazy; images sized, modern formats, dimensions set
- ☐ Fonts subset, preloaded, with metric-matched fallbacks
- ☐ Heavy libraries and 3D loaded after first paint

Meta and resilience

- ☐ Unique title and description per page; social share image; favicon set
- ☐ Designed 404; no broken links or console errors
- ☐ Tested in Chrome, Safari (including iOS) and Firefox
- ☐ Cookie consent where required, with reject as easy as accept

Appendix

Starter code, an easing library and ready prompts. The token values below are a neutral starting skeleton; the concept from Part 4 replaces every color, face and radius.

A. Starter foundation

```
@layer reset, tokens, base, components, utilities;

@layer reset {
  *, *::before, *::after { box-sizing: border-box; }
  * { margin: 0; }
  html { -webkit-text-size-adjust: 100%; text-size-adjust: 100%; }
  body { min-height: 100svh; -webkit-font-smoothing: antialiased; }
  img, picture, video, canvas, svg { display: block; max-width: 100%; height: auto; }
  input, button, textarea, select { font: inherit; }
  p, h1, h2, h3, h4 { overflow-wrap: break-word; }
}

@layer tokens {
  :root {
    color-scheme: light dark;
    /* space (4px base) */
    --space-1: 0.25rem; --space-2: 0.5rem; --space-3: 0.75rem; --space-4:
```

```

1rem;
  --space-6: 1.5rem; --space-8: 2rem; --space-12: 3rem; --space-16: 4rem;
  --space-24: 6rem; --space-32: 8rem;
  --section: clamp(4rem, 10vw, 10rem);
  --gutter: clamp(1rem, 5vw, 5rem);
  --measure: 65ch;
  /* radius: pick one personality and scale it */
  --radius-s: 4px; --radius-m: 8px; --radius-l: 16px;
  /* elevation: layered and tinted */
  --shadow-1: 0 1px 2px oklch(0.2 0.02 60 / 0.08);
  --shadow-2: 0 1px 2px oklch(0.2 0.02 60 / 0.06), 0 8px 24px oklch(0.2
0.02 60 / 0.08);
  /* motion */
  --ease-out: cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1);
  --ease-in: cubic-bezier(0.7, 0, 0.84, 0);
  --ease-in-out: cubic-bezier(0.65, 0, 0.35, 1);
  --dur-1: 120ms; --dur-2: 220ms; --dur-3: 380ms; --dur-4: 650ms;
}
}

@layer base {
  html { scroll-padding-top: 5rem; } /* keeps focus/anchors clear of sticky
headers */
  body { background: var(--bg); color: var(--text); font-size: var(--step-0);
line-height: 1.6; }
  h1, h2, h3 { line-height: 1.1; text-wrap: balance; }
  p { max-inline-size: var(--measure); text-wrap: pretty; }
  a { color: inherit; text-underline-offset: 0.18em; text-decoration-
thickness: 0.06em; }
  :focus-visible { outline: 2px solid var(--focus); outline-offset: 3px; }
  ::selection { background: var(--accent); color: var(--on-accent); }
  .tabular { font-variant-numeric: tabular-nums; }
}

@media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce) {
  *, *::before, *::after {
    animation-duration: 0.01ms !important; animation-iteration-count: 1
!important;
    transition-duration: 0.01ms !important; scroll-behavior: auto !important;
  }
}

```

B. Easing library

Name	Curve	Use
Out (expo-like)	<code>cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1)</code>	Entrances, reveals, popovers
Out (gentle)	<code>cubic-bezier(0.22, 1, 0.36, 1)</code>	Hover responses, small moves
In	<code>cubic-bezier(0.7, 0, 0.84, 0)</code>	Exits, dismissals
In-out	<code>cubic-bezier(0.65, 0, 0.35, 1)</code>	Toggles, there-and-back, page transitions
Linear	<code>linear</code>	Scroll-scrubbed timelines, continuous rotation only

C. Prompts that use this bible

1. New site — plan first

Follow the UI/UX Bible. Subject: [what, for whom, primary action, real content attached]. Run Part 4 steps 1–4 and show me the brief, three directions, the chosen concept and the token plan with ASCII wireframes. Do not write code until I approve.

2. Build and self-critique

Plan approved. Build it following Parts 5–15. Then run the Part 17 protocol on your own output: show the findings table and rubric scores, fix every high-impact finding, and tell me what you could not verify.

3. Redesign an existing site

Here is the current site [screenshots, URL or code]. Act as a harsh Awwwards juror: run the Part 2 slop scan and the Part 17 rubric, list findings by impact, propose a concept via Part 4, then implement the fixes in priority order.

4. Component audit

Audit this component against the Part 10 state matrix, Part 9 motion rules and Part 13 checklist. Return missing states and violations as a table, then the corrected code.

D. Sources

- [Awwwards — Evaluation System](#)
- [Hon Tran — How to Win an Awwwards Site of the Day](#)
- [Awwwards — Sites of the Year](#)
- [prg.sh — Why Your AI Keeps Building the Same Purple Gradient Website](#)
- [Superdesign — Why AI design looks generic](#)
- [925studios — AI slop fonts and gradients](#)
- [Noqta — AI design slop: overused UI patterns](#)
- [web.dev — Typography](#)
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- [Evil Martians — The OKLCH ecosystem](#)
- [Atmos — OKLCH color space](#)
- [Somerset Council — What's new in WCAG 2.2](#)
- [PowerMapper — WCAG 2.2 published](#)
- [Metadigital — Core Web Vitals in 2026](#)
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- [Baymard — Form design best practices](#)
- [Baymard — Avoid inline labels on mobile](#)
- [Nielsen Norman Group — Hidden navigation on desktop](#)
- [StudioMeyer — Web design trends 2026 reality check](#)